

IDENTITY WITHOUT THE NAME

This report examines how cybersecurity vendors' own brands are reused by third parties, and specifically measures a class of abuse that carries **no lexical trace of the brand at all** — no name, no typo, no permutation. Of 43 verified cases of vendor identity reuse, **26% fall into that class**. A further finding concerns a **259-domain family** impersonating corporate IT helpdesks using a security vendor's login identity.

Source: Webamon passive web-scan data 35 vendors anchored 43 verified reuse cases

verified live 2026-08-01

26% of verified reuse has no lexical link to the brand	259 domains in the helpdesk-* impersonation family
100% of that family registered within 2026	48/89 sampled domains still hosting when probed

01 METHOD AND ITS LIMITS

Detection anchors were taken from each vendor's own live site: the **favicon hash** (`favicons.mmh3`) and the **exact page title**. A domain carrying one of those artifacts is presenting that vendor's visual identity, regardless of what the domain is called.

Classification applied

- A Token-present** — the domain string contains the brand. Reachable by exact-string monitoring.
- B Permutation** — a recognisable distortion (typo, character swap). Reachable by fuzzy or edit-distance matching.
- C Token-absent** — no lexical relationship to the brand whatsoever. Not reachable by any name-based method; only by matching content.

Exclusions applied before counting

Corporate properties. Acquisitions and product sites legitimately carry a parent's favicon. `venafi.com` and `jetstack.io` (CyberArk), `emergingthreats.net` and `sendmail.org` (Proofpoint), `cadosecurity.com` (Darktrace), `egress.com` (KnowBe4), `humio.com` and `reposify.net` (CrowdStrike) were all excluded. Counting them as abuse would be wrong.

Generic favicons. Two vendor anchors were discarded after testing (\$05).

Scope limit, stated plainly. This measures *observed* identity reuse within Webamon's scan coverage. It is not a census of all abuse against these vendors, and the absolute counts are small. The proportional split between classes is the meaningful result, not the totals.

02 FINDING 1 — THE DETECTION-COVERAGE SPLIT

43 verified cases of vendor identity reuse, classified by lexical relationship to the brand.

Distribution across classes



Roughly **one in four** verified cases carries no brand string and no recognisable distortion of one. Those domains cannot be surfaced by monitoring that operates on the domain name.

By vendor

VENDOR	TOTAL	A	B	C
1Password	15	7	4	4
Okta	8	3	0	5
Palo Alto	7	6	0	1
LastPass	3	0	3	0
CrowdStrike	1	0	0	1
Norton · Malwarebytes · Darktrace · Keeper · Trend Micro · Kaspersky	9	7	2	0

Class C — the token-absent cases in full

DOMAIN	VENDOR IDENTITY CARRIED	OBSERVATION
helpdesk-jll[.]com	Okta	Impersonates the helpdesk of a named real-estate firm
helpdesk-affirm[.]com	Okta	Impersonates the helpdesk of a named fintech
helpdesk-westernunion[.]com	Okta	Impersonates the helpdesk of a named payments firm
addpasskey[.]com	Okta	Generic authentication-themed name
asqula[.]com	Okta	Invented word, no sector reference
google-update[.]xyz	CrowdStrike	Presents as an unrelated vendor's update service
007771[.]xyz	Palo Alto	Numeric label, no lexical content at all
agilebits[.]co / [.]us	1Password	Former corporate name; ownership unverified

Domains defanged. The `agilebits` entries are the historic corporate name of 1Password's developer and may be legitimate; they are reported here rather than silently removed because we could not confirm ownership either way.

03 FINDING 2 — THE HELPDESK-✱ FAMILY

A single naming convention, **259 domains**, every one registered during 2026. The pattern is `helpdesk-{organisation}` — impersonating the victim's own IT support function rather than any security vendor.

Growth through 2026



Registrations roughly 4× from January to July, with no month showing decline.

Named organisational targets

Financial services — Vanguard, ABN AMRO, Affirm, Alliant, ANZ NZ, ASB NZ, Citizens Bank, US Bank, Santander, Chase, Coinbase, Wise, Atomic Wallet

Healthcare — Abbott, athenahealth, Function Health

Travel — JetBlue, Choice Hotels · **Real estate** — JLL

Technology and security — Apple, Google, Microsoft, **1Password**, **Okta**

Two observations of analytic significance. First, the family includes `helpdesk-okta[.]com` and `helpdesk-1password[.]com` — the security vendors are themselves targets, not merely the identity being borrowed. Second, the convention inverts the usual assumption: the domain impersonates the *victim organisation*, while the *security vendor* supplies the login page. Monitoring for a vendor's name would not surface any of these; monitoring for a company's own name would surface only that company's.

04 RISK OBSERVATIONS

Stated as risks, without recommendation of any particular control.

ELEVATED

Identity-provider impersonation concentrates access. A convincing SSO login page does not yield one application's credentials — it yields the session that fronts all federated applications. The blast radius of a single successful capture is proportional to the breadth of the SSO estate.

ELEVATED

Helpdesk framing defeats user scepticism. Staff are trained to expect an SSO prompt when contacting internal IT. A domain named for their own employer's helpdesk, presenting their actual identity provider's login, is consistent with legitimate experience at every visible layer.

MATERIAL

Name-based monitoring has a measurable blind spot. On this sample it is roughly one quarter of verified cases. Organisations relying solely on domain-string or fuzzy-match monitoring should treat their coverage figures as an underestimate of exposure by approximately that margin.

MATERIAL

Password managers attract disproportionate reuse. 1Password and LastPass together account for 18 of 43 verified cases. A credential vault is a single point of compromise for every secret it holds.

CONTEXTUAL

Takedown outcomes differ by class. Of the sampled heLpdesk-* domains, 38 of 69 had been removed by the time of probing. Of the token-absent cases, most remained live — consistent with abuse that is harder to report because there is no brand string to cite.

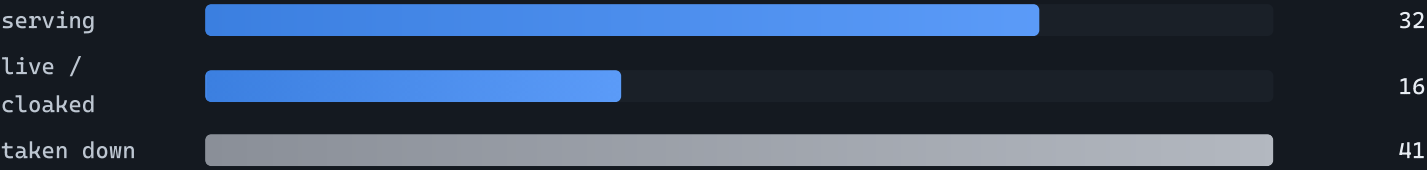
05 METHOD FAILURES ENCOUNTERED

Three findings were produced during this analysis and then discarded. They are recorded because each would have materially changed the reported figures.

DISCARDED DURING VALIDATION

1. **"199 token-absent McAfee cases" and "199 for Sophos".** Both vendor favicons proved to be **generic defaults**, not brand-specific. The Sophos hash appears on 220 domains of which **all 220** carry a blank page title and an identical 1,842-byte icon; the McAfee hash on 337 domains, 325 blank. Including them would have reported the token-absent share as **59%** rather than 26%. Favicon anchors must be validated for uniqueness before use.
2. **"1,655 Malwarebytes impersonations."** One of three candidate hashes was generic, returning domains titled *Sophos*, *GTT* and unrelated media sites. The two genuine hashes return three domains.
3. **"344 Palo Alto impersonations."** Exact-title matching on a two-word brand returned California real-estate listings — *1015 High St, Palo Alto, Best Palo Alto Real Estate Agent*. Brands that are also place names require geographic exclusion. The same applied to Norton (Chipping Norton, Hook Norton).

89 sampled domains, probed 2026-08-01



DNS → TCP → TLS → HTTP. Domains returning no HTTP response but completing a TLS handshake are recorded as live rather than removed.

Survival by class

CLASS	STILL HOSTING
helpdesk-* family	31 / 69
1Password — token-absent	4 / 4
1Password — permutation	4 / 4
LastPass — permutation	3 / 3
Okta — token-absent	2 / 5
CrowdStrike · Palo Alto — token-absent	2 / 2

Queries used in this analysis

Reproducible against the Webamon scans index.

```
# Vendor identity on domains not containing the vendor name
favicons.mmh3:(<vendor hash>) AND NOT domain_name:*<vendor>*

# Validate a favicon anchor before trusting it – a generic icon returns
# hundreds of domains with blank titles and one identical byte-length
favicons.mmh3:<hash>    -> check cardinality, title diversity, content_length

# The helpdesk-* convention
domain_name:helpdesk-*

# Exact product-surface titles on unrelated domains
page_title:"<vendor login page title>" AND NOT domain_name:*<vendor>*
```